

JOHN A. PFEFFER

1844 – 1908

*Merchant and banker of Columbia, Illinois —
and the man who gave a home to Mary “Marietta”
Blackwell*

A Babcock Family History paper
compiled September 2026

A DEATH FAR FROM HOME

On the afternoon of Tuesday, August 25, 1908, a telegram reached the German merchant families of Belleville and Waterloo, Illinois, with news that stopped conversation in half a dozen stores at once: John A. Pfeffer, one of Columbia's best-known and most respected citizens, was dead — not at home in his own bed, but on an operating table in a hospital in Paducah, Kentucky, more than a hundred miles from the town where he had lived his entire sixty-two years. He had gone there under strange and unlucky circumstances, thrown from a buggy while visiting a resort town in southern Illinois, and had died under the anesthetic while a doctor tried to set his broken hip.

It is a jarring way to begin a life story, but it is where this family's connection to John Pfeffer actually starts to matter: he was a stranger to us by blood, but not by choice. Some three decades before his death, he and his wife had opened their home to a small girl who had no parents of record and no name that was truly her own. They raised her, gave her their family's own name, and by every scrap of evidence that survives, simply made her one of their own children. That girl grew up to be Mary "Marietta" Blackwell, daughter of Ann Blackwell — and, through her marriage into the Brand family, an ancestor of this family today. This is the story of the man and the household that took her in.

FROM BAVARIA TO THE BOTTOMLANDS

John A. Pfeffer was born on August 1, 1844, into a family that had already crossed an ocean and half a continent to get where it was. His father — also named John Pfeffer — had been born and raised in the town of Kandel, in Bavaria, and in 1832, as a boy, had come to America with his own parents. The family landed at New Orleans, and it was there, almost immediately, that tragedy struck: John A.'s grandfather died shortly after arriving. His widow was left to bring five children up the river alone, and in 1840 she settled the family in Illinois. One daughter stayed behind in New Orleans and married a man named Fred Eckel; the rest of the family put down roots on a farm in Centreville Township, St. Clair County, where young John Pfeffer and his brother spent years clearing timber and turning raw land into a working farm.

But farming was not the only trade the family knew. For a time, father and uncle also worked the river itself, steamboating freight and passengers on the Mississippi between St. Louis and New Orleans — the same river route the family had traveled as immigrants years before. It was on a return trip to New Orleans that the elder John Pfeffer met and married Margaret Scherrer, herself an immigrant, from Lorraine in France. The young couple came back north to Illinois, where he tried farming a partly-improved tract in Monroe County for a year before giving it up for a very different line of work: five years as an engineer in a distillery in St. Louis. By 1852 he was farming again, and in 1856 he made the move that would define the family for the next half-century, partnering with his brother-in-law, F. X. Brohammer, to open a combined saloon and general store in the small river town of Columbia, Illinois.

The partnership lasted only a year before the two men split the stock between them, but the elder Pfeffer kept right on trading in Columbia — for more than three decades, in fact, until 1890, when he finally sold the business to his son and namesake. He died that October, and his wife, Margaret, followed him in death two years later, in October 1892. Of their fourteen children, only two lived to see 1894: their son John A., and a daughter, Mrs. Catherine Dollar, also of Columbia. The elder Pfeffer was remembered as a Democrat, a onetime town trustee, a devout member of the Catholic Church, and, in the plain words of a local history published while he was still fresh in memory, “a successful business man” who left an estate worth \$40,000 — a genuinely large sum for a small-town Illinois merchant in 1890.

and Road Commissioner for a number of years, proving himself well qualified for the positions by the able way in which he discharged the duties of his offices. Personally he is one of the most genial and companionable of men, strictly honorable in his dealings, and therefore highly regarded by all with whom he has to do.

David Smith, an elder brother of our subject, enlisted in the Tenth Illinois Infantry, in the same company with our subject, and took part in all the engagements with his regiment, always being found at his post of duty. After the close of the war he emigrated to Idaho, engaging in mining, and there died in 1878.

JOHN A. PFEFFER is a worthy representative of the business interests of Columbia, where he is engaged in general merchandising. As he is widely and favorably known in this community, we feel assured that the record of his life will prove of interest to many of our readers. He was born in St. Clair County, Ill., August 1, 1844, and is of German descent. His father, John Pfeffer, was born and reared in the city of Candel, Bavaria, Germany, and in 1832 came with his parents to America, the family landing in New Orleans, where the grandfather of our subject died. In 1840 his wife, with her five children, came to Illinois. One of the sisters remained in the Crescent City, and there married Fred Eckel. The family settled on a farm in Centreville Township, St. Clair County, and John Pfeffer and his brother cleared and improved the land, transforming it into a fine farm. They also engaged in steamboating on the Mississippi between St. Louis and New Orleans.

In the latter place the father of our subject married Margaret Scherrer, a native of Lorraine, France, who came to America in 1836. Mr. Pfeffer afterwards bought a farm of partially improved land in Monroe County and continued its cultivation for a year. He then went to St. Louis, where he worked about five years as an engineer in a distillery. From 1852 until 1856 he again carried on his farm, and then came with his brother-in-law, F. X. Brohammer, to Columbia, where they conducted

a saloon and mercantile business. In 1857 the stock was divided, and Mr. Pfeffer continued alone in trade until 1890, when he sold out to his son. His death occurred on the 16th of October following, and his wife died October 12, 1892. They were the parents of fourteen children, but only two are now living, John A., of this sketch, and Mrs. Catherine Dollar, of Columbia. In politics Mr. Pfeffer was a Democrat, and was Trustee of his town. He held membership with the Roman Catholic Church. He was a successful business man, and at his death left an estate valued at \$40,000.

Our subject was a lad of twelve when his father established business in Columbia. He clerked in the store until his marriage, when his father gave him the saloon, which he carried on until 1890, when he bought out the mercantile establishment. He has since carried on operations along that line, and by well directed efforts and good management has secured a fine trade. He now occupies a large store, which is well stocked with everything found in his line.

May 22, 1866, Mr. Pfeffer was united in marriage with Miss Johanna K. Funk, daughter of John Funk, of St. Clair County. Her father was a native of Bavaria, Germany, and in 1845 came to the New World, locating in St. Clair County. Mrs. Pfeffer was born in New Orleans, February 10, 1845. By their marriage they had fourteen children, of whom the following are yet living: John Joseph, who is clerking for his father; Joseph F., who is studying medicine in St. Louis; E. A. F., Peter A., Mary, Theodore, Annie; Louis and Katie, twins, and Charlie. Mary Ann died at the age of three years, John at the age of ten months, and Louis at the age of nine days. John Joseph married Bertha Reis, a daughter of Charles P. Reis.

In his political views, Mr. Pfeffer is a Democrat, and has been a member of the Village Board of Trustees, while for eleven years he served as a member of the School Board. In his undertakings he has met with prosperity, and in connection with the interests previously mentioned, he has a farm of two hundred and ninety-three acres that yields to him a good income. His home is a commodious and substantial brick residence. Mr. and Mrs.

The opening of John A. Pfeffer's biographical sketch, in a county history published while he was fifty years old and near the height of his career. — Portrait and Biographical Record of Randolph, Jackson, Perry and Monroe Counties, Illinois (1894), p. 411.

A MERCHANT IN HIS OWN RIGHT

John A. Pfeffer was only twelve years old when his father opened that first store in Columbia, and he grew up inside it, clerking behind the counter as a boy and a young man. When he married, his father handed him the saloon side of the business to run as his own, and John A. kept at it for nearly three decades. Then, in 1890 — the same year his father retired and sold out — John A. bought the mercantile store outright and became a general merchant in full. By the time a county historian came calling in 1894 to record his life story, Pfeffer was, in the historian's words, running "a large store, which is well stocked with everything found in his line," the product of what the same account calls "well directed efforts and good management."

The store was not his only concern. Alongside it he held a farm of two hundred and ninety-three acres — a substantial holding for a man who spent most of his working life behind a counter — and lived with his family in what was described as “a commodious and substantial brick residence.” He was, by every surviving account, a man who had made good.

JOHANNA FUNK AND A HOUSE FULL OF CHILDREN

On May 22, 1862, John A. Pfeffer married Johanna K. Funk, the daughter of a fellow Bavarian immigrant, John Funk of St. Clair County. (A county history published decades later gives the date as 1866, but the couple’s own household, recorded in the 1900 census as married thirty-eight years, confirms 1862 as correct.) Johanna had been born in New Orleans on February 10, 1845, and had come north to Illinois as a small child, much as her husband’s own family had.

Together the couple had fourteen children. By 1894, ten of them were living: John Joseph, who clerked in his father’s store and had married Bertha Reis; Joseph F., who was off studying medicine in St. Louis; a son recorded only as E. A. F.; Peter A.; a daughter named Mary; a son named Theodore; a daughter named Annie; twins Louis and Katie; and the youngest, Charlie. Three children had not survived infancy: a daughter, Mary Ann, who died at three years old; a son, John, who lived only ten months; and an earlier son also named Louis, who died at just nine days old — his name later given to the twin brother born after him, a common and poignant practice of the era, meant to carry a lost child’s name forward in the family.

Two of the Pfeffer sons went on to become physicians. Joseph F. — whom the 1908 newspapers would identify as Dr. Francis Joseph Pfeffer — and his brother Dr. Peter A. Pfeffer both built medical practices in St. Louis, while a third son, Theodore J., also settled there. By the time of Johanna’s own death in 1915, eleven of the fourteen children she had borne — seven sons and four daughters — were still living, and the couple counted twenty-eight grandchildren.

TWO DAUGHTERS WHO WERE NOT BORN TO THEM

Alongside their own large family, John A. and Johanna Pfeffer took in two children who were not born to them at all. The 1894 county history records the fact in a single warm sentence: “Mr. and Mrs. Pfeffer are noted for their kindness, and through their generosity gave homes to two adopted children.”

The first was Elizabeth Smith, who grew up in the Pfeffer household and later married Frank L. Riebeling, a wagon maker in the nearby town of Ava, in Jackson County. The second, still living at home and seventeen years old when the 1894 sketch was written, was recorded simply as “Johanna Mary.”

That name was not a coincidence. It was a deliberate echo of her adoptive mother’s own name — Johanna K. Funk Pfeffer — a small, permanent gesture of belonging given to a child who had arrived in the family with a very different history. She had been born Mary Blackwell, in February 1877, the daughter of an unmarried Irish immigrant named Ann Blackwell, and her earliest recorded years were spent not in a home like the Pfeffers’ but in the Oneida County Poorhouse in Rome, New York, where her mother had been living at the time of her birth. New York law at the time required children over the age of two to be removed from poorhouses, which is almost certainly how a small girl from upstate New York eventually came to be raised by a German merchant family in southern Illinois — likely through one of the orphan-placement charities of the era that moved children from crowded Eastern institutions into Midwestern homes.

In the Pfeffer household she was given the name Johanna Mary, but everyone seems to have simply called her Jennie. The 1900 census, taken when she was in her early twenties, lists her plainly: “Jennie Pfeffer,” born in New York, the household’s adopted daughter. And in the spring of 1904, months before her wedding, the local paper in nearby Waterloo ran the smallest and most ordinary kind of notice about her — the kind of item that filled every small-town paper of the era — simply noting that “Miss Jennie Pfeffer of Columbia is the guest of Miss Celia Leibach.” It is a throwaway line, but it is also, in its way, the clearest evidence there is that she had become exactly what the Pfeffers must have intended: an ordinary, unremarked-upon young woman of the town, visiting friends and living her life under their name, with nothing in the public record to mark her out as anything but one of their own.

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oeke invited a last Sunday to their daughter	Wm. Feldmeier sen., of Chalfin Bridge was a Waterloo visitor Saturday.	
	Chas. Klingelberg of Maeystown trans- acted business in our city today.	
	W. H. Limestall of Brownsburg tran- sacted business in our city Tuesday.	
	Peter Placsterer of Harrisonville tran- sacted business in the hub Monday.	
	Philip Bodenbach of Chalfin Bridge circulated about the capital Monday.	
	Mrs. G. A. Osterholt of Chicago, Ill., is visiting her parents Mr. and Mrs. P. P. Bremser.	Loa Dis Pai

“Miss Jennie Pfeffer of Columbia is the guest of Miss Celia Leibach” — the only known contemporary newspaper mention of Mary Blackwell by name, a few months before her wedding. Waterloo Republican, May 18, 1904.

Later that year, she married Jacob Emil Brand — under her birth name, Marietta Blackwell, rather than the Pfeffer name she had grown up with. She and Jacob are buried together at Immaculate Conception Catholic Cemetery in Columbia, in a plot directly behind John A. and Johanna Pfeffer’s own graves — a quiet, permanent statement of where the family considered her to belong, long after she had a household and children of her own.

A TRUSTED MAN OF COLUMBIA

Beyond his store, John A. Pfeffer built the kind of reputation that got a man elected, appointed, and asked to serve. He was a director of the First National Bank of Waterloo — a position of real standing in a small county-seat town — and sat for years on Columbia’s Village Board of Trustees. For eleven years he served on the local School Board.

He was also, in the way of many German-American communities of the era, active in the town's social and athletic life. In 1896 he was president of the Columbia Gymnastic Society, a local Turner club, and stepped down from the presidency that November only to be immediately elected one of the club's three trustees. The following spring, when a group of area farmers met to organize a cooperative creamery, it was Pfeffer who was chosen secretary of the meeting and appointed one of three commissioners charged with selling stock in the new venture — a genuine piece of local agricultural development, and a natural fit for a man who ran a farm of nearly three hundred acres alongside his store. He also did the ordinary civic duty expected of a trusted citizen, serving at least once as an election judge for his home precinct.

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John A. Pfeffer opens the 1896 annual meeting of the Columbia Gymnastic Society as its outgoing president, and is elected a trustee for the coming year. Waterloo Republic-Times, November 12, 1896.

THROWN FROM A BUGGY

In the last week of August 1908, Pfeffer — by then a well-to-do, semi-retired merchant of sixty-two — was visiting Creal Springs, a small resort town in southern Illinois known for its mineral springs. While he was there, the horse pulling his buggy bolted. Thrown from his seat, Pfeffer fractured his hip. He was taken across the Ohio River to a hospital in Paducah, Kentucky — presumably the nearest facility equipped to treat him — where a doctor set about repairing the break.

“His relatives state that he died while he was under the influence of chloroform, undergoing the setting of the fractured hip.”

— Belleville Daily Advocate, August 26, 1908

He never came off the table. Chloroform anesthesia, standard practice at the time, carried real and recognized risks — anesthetic deaths of exactly this kind, sudden and unpredictable, were common enough in 1908 medicine to warrant no particular scandal, only grief. Pfeffer’s death made the front page of the Belleville Daily Advocate the following day, under the stark headline “Died of Chloroform.”

His body was brought home by train, passing through East St. Louis on its way to Columbia. There, three of his sons who had built lives in the city — Dr. Peter A. Pfeffer of Shaw Avenue, Dr. Francis Joseph Pfeffer of South Jefferson Avenue, and Theodore J. Pfeffer of Ashland Avenue — met the train, along with a fourth son, John J., who came from his home in Lebanon, Illinois. All of them rode the rest of the way to Columbia with their father’s body. Waiting there was his widow, Johanna, and the several of their children who still lived at home.



“Died of Chloroform” — the front-page report of John A. Pfeffer’s death. Belleville Daily Advocate, August 26, 1908, p. 1.

AFTERWARD

Johanna Pfeffer lived another seven years as a widow in the Columbia home she and John had shared. When she died on November 15, 1915, at seventy years old, the local paper remembered her husband as “for many years one of our prominent merchants,” and noted that she left behind eleven living children and twenty-eight grandchildren — a family that had, by then, scattered from Columbia into St. Louis, Lebanon, and beyond, but had clearly stayed close. She was buried beside her husband in the Catholic cemetery at Columbia, following a requiem mass at the church she had belonged to for decades.

After the wedding party the bride's wedding feast young couple near Sutherland the happy life.	to attend the services which begin at 10 a. m. The goat in our local Harugari lodge was treated to a frolic Monday evening when C. W. Breidecker, Wm. Goekeler and George Eckert were initiated as members. Delegations from Waterloo and Belleville were here to see the fun and spent a royal good time. A social session took place after the initiation. Died, at her home in this city, on Monday, November 15, 1915, Mrs. Johanna Pfeffer, nee Funk, widow of the late John A. Pfeffer, aged 70 years, 9 months and 5 days. Deceased was born in New Orleans, Feb. 10, 1845. While still in her teens she came north with her parents and on May 22, 1862, she was married to John A. Pfeffer, for many years one of our prominent merchants, who preceded her in death several years ago. To this union were born eleven children, seven sons and four daughters, all of whom survive and have grown up. Twenty-eight grand-children also survive. The funeral takes place in the Catholic cemetery here this (Thursday) morning after requiem mass in the Catholic church of which deceased was a devout member. The bereaved relatives have the sincere sympathy of all in the loss of their dearest friend on earth.	the foundation will be week. Mr. Dann had work there and they deep that it took two the force of men out. me boys, they dug some FULTS Mr. and Mrs. Theo. S. Mr. and Mrs. Fred Jos Geo. Cavanaugh tr ness in Prairie du Roch Mr. and Mrs. Philip nock visited Chas. I Sunday. Mr. and Mrs. Hy. visiting relatives in Missouri. Messrs. James and dinner with W. H. Lim ily Sunday. John Rosemann and spent the week-end Mrs. Hy. Sutter. John I. Powderly we Friday evening but ret to attend the box socie Mr. and Mrs. Chas. near Hecker visited t Mrs. August Oelzen, Monday. The box supper at was well attended and
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The obituary of Johanna (Funk) Pfeffer, John A.'s widow, who outlived him by seven years. Waterloo Republic-Times, November 19, 1915.

Their adopted daughter, by then Marietta Brand, had her own household in the region by this time, raising children of her own — children who would eventually connect this Bavarian merchant family, by marriage, to the Babcock line that carries this history forward today. Whatever Mary Blackwell's life might have looked like had she stayed in the Oneida County Poorhouse, it looked instead like a childhood in a large, prosperous, close-knit Illinois family — and that, more than any single fact in his biography, may be the truest measure of the man who took her in.

A NOTE ON ONE OPEN QUESTION

Two good sources disagree about where John A. Pfeffer was actually born. The 1894 county history, most likely based on an interview with Pfeffer himself, places his birth in St. Clair County, Illinois. His own obituary in 1908, presumably based on information from his grieving family, states instead that he was born "at Third and Market streets in St. Louis." Both are otherwise reliable accounts, and nothing found so far resolves the conflict. It is recorded here rather than settled one way or the other, in case a birth or baptismal record ever turns up to decide it.

SOURCES

- *Portrait and Biographical Record of Randolph, Jackson, Perry and Monroe Counties, Illinois* (Biographical Publishing Co., Chicago, 1894), pp. 411–412 — full biographical sketch of John A. Pfeffer and his father.
- “Died of Chloroform,” *Belleville Daily Advocate*, Belleville, Illinois, August 26, 1908, p. 1.
- “Mrs. Johanna Pfeffer” (obituary), *Waterloo Republic-Times*, Waterloo, Illinois, November 19, 1915, p. 8.
- “The annual meeting of the Columbia Gymnastic Society...,” *Waterloo Republic-Times*, November 12, 1896, p. 3.
- “A mass meeting of farmers and others...” (creamery organization), *Waterloo Republican*, March 25, 1897, p. 5.
- “Miss Jennie Pfeffer of Columbia...,” *Waterloo Republican*, May 18, 1904, p. 5.
- “On account of the Pfeffer funeral...” (First National Bank closure), *Waterloo Republican*, September 2, 1908, p. 8.
- 1900 United States Federal Census, Columbia, Monroe County, Illinois — John A. Pfeffer household.
- Immaculate Conception Catholic Cemetery, Columbia, Illinois, parish lot index — Pfeffer and Brand family plots.

Full transcriptions, source images, and additional research notes are preserved in the Babcock Family History research archive.